

WAITING GAME Rahul and Sonia at the AICC's two-day 'Chintan Shivir' in Jaipur, Jan. 2013

HINDUSTAN TIMES

HAVING CHOSEN TO TURN DOWN MINISTERSHIP, RAHUL WAS A RELUCTANT POWER POLITICIAN, ILL-SUITED TO SHEPHERD A FLAILING PARTY

the Right to Information and the Right to Education. "Manmohanomics with Sonia-politics, liberalisation with a human face," is how one key official explained the vision of the time, pointing to the record number of people lifted out of poverty during this period. A study—the Oxford Poverty and Human Development Initiative—has claimed that 270 million people were lifted out of poverty between 2005 and 2015.

But in the very success of the UPA experiment in its initial years were sown the seeds of its eventual demise. Keen to assert its ideological rigidity, the Left would snipe periodically at Dr Singh, especially over his open advocacy of greater foreign investment in crucial sectors. The Sonia Gandhi-led National Advisory Council, a gathering of well-intentioned, mostly Left-leaning NGOs, was also pushing their agenda of equity-centric growth. Increasingly hemmed in, Dr Singh attempted to break free by helming the India-United States Civil Nuclear Agreement 2008, a landmark pact designed to end India's nuclear isolation but also redraw the on-off New Delhi-Washington relationship. If economic liberalisation had pitched Dr Singh as the path-breaking finance minister who shed decades of socialistic



◀ Top to bottom: Sept. 12, 2005; Dec. 3, 2012; Oct. 14, 2013; Jun. 2, 2014

Rahul Gandhi Rises and Falls

Rahul Gandhi's rise was carefully stage-managed as the Congress's generational renewal. Entering Parliament in 2004, he was projected as a clean, idealistic counterpoint to cynical politics and gradually emerged as a parallel power centre within the government and party. As corruption scandals, policy paralysis and economic slowdown engulfed the UPA, he struggled to convert intent into authority. By 2014, he had become inseparable from the government's failures, presiding over the Congress's worst-ever electoral defeat and the collapse of his own leadership claim.